SOUTH ASIAN ASSOCIATION FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION

The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) was established when its Charter was formally adopted on 8 December 1985 by the Heads of States or Governments of Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka in their First SAARC Summit in Dhaka on 7–8 December 1985. Afghanistan was added to the regional grouping at the behest of India on 13 November, 2005, and became a member on 3 April, 2007. With the addition of Afghanistan, the total number of member states now stands at eight. The observers are Australia, China, the European Union, Iran, Japan Mauritius, Myanmar (Burma), South Korea and the United States.

The South Asian neighbours began to take initiative towards regional cooperation in the 1980s, primarily under the initiative of President Zia-ur Rehman of Bangladesh. Between 1970 and 1980, he paid visits to Nepal, Pakistan, India and Sri Lanka to concretize the idea of cooperation among the South Asian neighbours. Several Foreign Secretary-level meetings followed in Colombo, Kathmandu, Islamabad, and Dhaka. It was followed by the first meeting of the Foreign Ministers at New Delhi in August 1983. It was at this meeting that the Foreign Ministers adopted the Declaration on South Asian Association Regional Cooperation. They also launched the Integrated Programme of Action (IPA) in nine agreed areas, namely, agriculture; rural development; telecommunications; meteorology; health and population activities; transport; postal services; science and technology; and sports, arts and culture.

At the inception of the Association, the IPA consisting of a number of Technical Committees was identified as the core area of cooperation. But given the changed circumstances over the years, the current areas of cooperation, under the reconstituted Regional Integrated Programme of Action which is pursued through the Technical Committees cover:

1. Agriculture and Rural Development
2. Health and Population Activities
3. Women, Youth and Children